Voyage Accounts of European Slave Trade Ventures, 1600–1830

Abstract

This dataset compiles financial information from 641 transatlantic slave-trading ventures (together comprising 720 voyages) between 1600 and 1830, undertaken by traders from Great Britain, the Netherlands, France, Denmark, Portugal/Brazil and Spain/Cuba. The data were primarily assembled from secondary sources (published accounts and archival compilations) complemented by original research on primary archival materials. The dataset includes systematic information on outlays, returns, insurance, and ship value. For comparative purposes, each venture was linked to the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database (TSTD), which also allows for the use of imputed variables from the TSTD when primary data is missing to complete venture metadata. All sources used are documented at the venture level. The dataset supports the study of historical maritime finance, profitability under risk, and differences in commercial organization across empires.

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Background & Summary

The Atlantic slave trade was the largest long-distance forced migration in human history. It played a crucial role in shaping the early modern global economy. Understanding how the capital required for this trade was mobilized, invested and returned offers valuable insights into the operation of early modern capitalism. Moreover, the profitability of the Atlantic slave trade is a subject of ongoing scholarly debate, with some scholars arguing that these profits were foundational to the economic development of modern societies[1,2]. However, previous studies have based their claims on data from a single port, nationality or trader, or have worked with highly speculative profit assumptions. This project brings together fragmented datasets, supplements them with new archival work and applies a consistent framework so that profits and risks can be compared across multiple legal regimes.

A multi-national financial dataset of this scale has not been attempted before for the Atlantic slave trade, providing a unique resource for researchers. The primary value of this dataset lies in its potential for reuse in a wide range of historical and economic research. Maritime and business historians gain direct evidence on credit arrangements, depreciation rules and investor networks otherwise hidden in ledgers. Economic historians can revisit debates on profitability, economies of scale or the impact of mortality shocks using transparent underlying numbers. Furthermore, the dataset was designed to be interoperable with the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database (TSTD), which is the principal international repository of voyage-level data on the Atlantic slave trade and serves as the standard reference point for quantitative research in the field[3]. This interoperability significantly enhances the reuse potential of this dataset. Where possible, voyages have been matched with their corresponding entries in the TSTD using the TSTD Voyage IDs. This allows researchers to easily link

our financial data with the extensive demographic and geographic information in the TSTD, such as the number of enslaved people embarked and disembarked, mortality rates, and regions of trade in Africa and the Americas.

Methods

The dataset was created by systematically gathering and standardizing financial information on individual slave-trading ventures. It is a compilation of numerous secondary and primary sources, including archival ledgers, data shared by researchers, and printed works. The specific sources for each venture are provided within the dataset. The main sources and characteristics of the data for each nationality are described in the section on Input Data below.

Data Entry Procedure

All entries in this dataset were added by the authors of the data descriptor. Each author surveyed the available archival material and datasets from their area of expertise. To facilitate the data entry process, we relied on two principal data structures: one designed to capture information on individual ventures and another designed to record expenditures and returns associated with those ventures. Both structures took the form of a csv file with predefined column names. A dedicated Data Entry Handbook ensured consistent use of terminology, format and judgment for ambiguous cases.

We included financial details on ventures from different perspectives, including firm level, investor level, and associate level accounts. In all cases, the source's perspective has been documented in the “perspective_of_source” column of in the venture data. Dates were entered in a YYYY-MM-DD format. If only partial dates were available in sources (e.g. year or year-month), only these were entered (e.g. only YYYY or YYYY-MM) in order to avoid introducing artificial precision.

Where possible, the venture data includes details like the names of ships, investors, captains and outfitters. It also includes details on a venture's itinerary and about the number of enslaved persons bought and sold. These data are taken from the primary or secondary sources mentioned for each venture and may differ from the data in the TSTD. We have manually added accompanying TSTD Voyage IDs to ventures in our dataset where possible. If a venture in our dataset comprised multiple TSTD Voyages, we have included these in one field separated by a forward slash (/). Users of our dataset may find additional contextual information on ventures by linking up with the TSTD.

The financial account entries include both expenditures and returns. Every individual entry was recorded in a separate row. The specification of each entry was left to the researcher entering the data, based on their interpretation of the original source. We did not employ a strict controlled vocabulary for the specification, although the Data Entry Handbook did provide suggested values. Each entry was recorded as in the source, using the source currency, with values given to two decimal places or in fractional form. If the source included information on the year or exact date of transactions, we have included this information in our dataset. We also include a crude timing estimate as a separate variable using a controlled vocabulary (Outfitting, After Outfitting but before departure, Transactions during voyage, Return, Unknown).

Data Standardization

Each entry was initially given a label by the researcher entering the data into the template. To support cross-national and longitudinal analysis, most transactions were afterwards mapped to a broader

category, based on the content of its original label. This mapping was informed by recurring terms across all sources and refined into a controlled vocabulary of the following 19 categories:

Expenditures

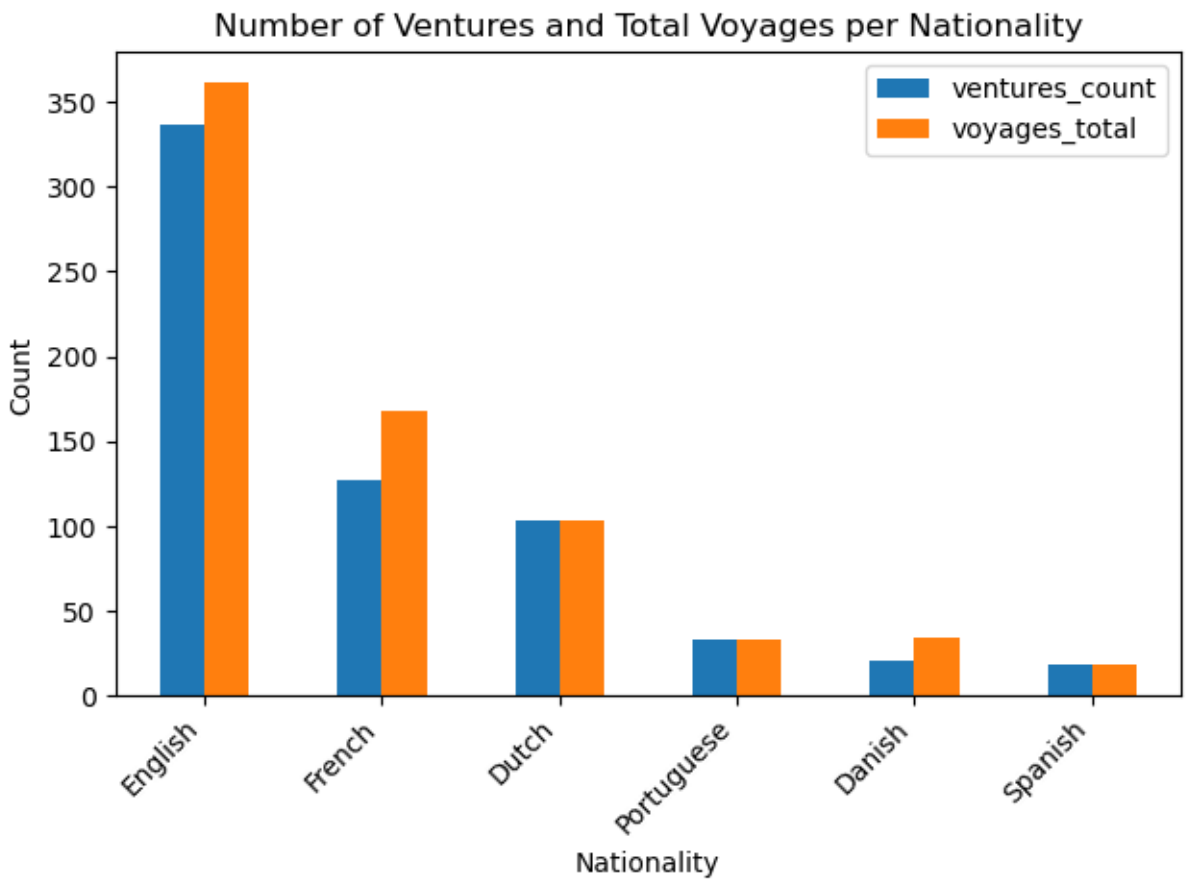
Ship value before departure, crew costs, outfitting, trade cargo, insurance premiums, commissions, taxes, victuals, credit, debt, various expenses and unknown entries.

Returns

Sale of enslaved individuals, proceeds from other goods, freight and passenger income, insurance payouts, cash received, trade cargo returns, assessed value of the ship upon return and unknown entries.

Transactions that have no assigned category can be reviewed in future updates.

Figure 1. Number of ventures and total voyages per nationality



Input data

Data on British slave trade

The British data come from different sources. All of the sources are from the accounts of private traders. The most important traders in the dataset are William Davenport (94 ventures), John

Tomlinson and John Knight (30 ventures), Joan Goad (Hassell papers, 19 ventures), James Rogers (14 ventures), Nicholas Torre (14 ventures), David Tuohy (12 ventures), James Day (11 ventures), Thomas Lumley (8 ventures) and Thomas Leyland (6 ventures). Some, but far from all, of these sources have been used in previous research[4–7].The accounts from the Davenport records were digitized by Nick Radburn, who generously shared his dataset. The vast majority of the other records were collected for this project by David Richardson from primary and secondary sources, with assistance in digitizing the data by Klas Rönnbäck. The accounts from the sources differ in terms of how complete they are, and how well-ordered they are. Some of the accounts are in a state of disarray. The reported categories of expenditures and returns differ between the accounts. For many of the traders, it is known that they invested in more slave trading ventures than the ones above, but accounts for these other voyages have not survived (if they ever existed).

Notes on interpreting the British data

As a rule, British slave trading ventures were undertaken by a group of traders, with one of them acting as the ship's husband. The accounts were made up to settle the affairs between the investors in the venture. In some cases (e.g. James Rogers' or Thomas Lumley's accounts), the records have survived because the trader got involved in legal disputes, and the records were used as evidence. Most of the accounts are per voyage of a single ship, but the sources occasionally report data for two (or, in one single case, three) ships that presumably sailed together. The accounts are reported by full voyage. Only occasionally is the date of individual transactions recorded.

Insurance was as a rule not taken out by the ship's husband, but by individual investors. Insurance costs are therefore not always to be found in the accounts of the voyages. They were presumably reported separately. Such separate accounting of insurance is in many cases missing in our dataset. It is not possible to tell for certain if this is due to a) the trader not purchasing any insurance, b) the trader purchasing insurance but not recording it in any account, or only in an account that has since gone missing in the archival materials, or c) insurance was purchased, but accounts of this have not been found by the researchers, for example if the accounts are in some disarray. Insurance was usually arranged before the voyage, but additional policies could also be added during a voyage ([8], p. 19).

For many of the British ventures, the value of the ship is known, either when purchased in the first place, or when sold after the completion of a voyage, or for both of these. If the same ship was used for several voyages, the traders do not seem as a rule to have included the value of the ship in the accounts of the successive voyages (except when the ship was eventually sold). The value of the ship is (at best) therefore recorded only on its first voyage, and on its last voyage.

When the Royal African Company lost its monopoly in 1697, private merchants had to pay a levy (10%) on goods exported from Africa to the RAC. That levy seems to have expired in 1712 ([9], p. 151). Afterwards, the trade was subject to normal duties, like those on imports. What taxes or customs there are seem to be included in the accounts, as far as it is possible to tell.

The returns are often in the form of bills of exchange. In some cases, the sources report the length of payment, which often seem to be in separate tranches, but this is not reported systematically for all ventures. Other returns are in the form of the sales of various commodities, and it is not always reported when these were sold. Nick Radburn has shown that the length of credit for slave sales increased during the late 18th century from less than 5 months on average in the 1750s, to 15-20 months by the 1780s ([10], figure 1) In a few cases, some debt is reported to be outstanding in the Caribbean.

Data on French slave trade

The French data included in this dataset consists of 127 ventures. All of them come, directly or indirectly, from outfitting accounts (*comptes d'armement*) or return accounts (*comptes de désarmement*) that were made by outfitters for the benefit of their investors. We do not know of any surviving document that would recapitulate cost and benefit of a particular slave expedition for the outfitter, though some recapitulation must be present in their own account books. The main source of accounts are the archives from the Bertrand de Cœuvre's estate, assembled by Meyer[11]. Bertrand de Cœuvre was an investor in many slave-trading voyages. For 35 of them, we have the full cash flows as compiled by the estate's executors. They give the amount paid for the outfitting (one figure, no date) and between the outfitting and the departure (one figure, no date). They also provide the return cash flows day by day. Sometimes they mention that some funds were still to be collected with the date of the account giving that information. These accounts are given by ship or group of ships that sailed together. The returns cash flows are not associated to a specific voyage. Additional data from other traders has been assembled from previous research[12–16]. Thanks to Silvia Marzagalli, we have also retranscribed the outfitting and return account book (*Livre des compte d'armement et de désarmement*) of François Castaing which is in the Municipal archives of Bordeaux (1 S 3)[17].

Notes on interpreting the French data

The information on insurance is contradictory in the French data. Sometimes, insurance is paid by the outfitter (usually without commission), and so will be included in the accounts. Sometimes it is paid by the investors and might be missed. Meyer argues that it should be integrated as a cost at outfitting of the ship. However, Butel argues (based on an early 1750s memoire) that there were huge delays for the payment of premium.([18], p. 717) Similarly, other scholars have argued that the practice was to pay the insurance premium upon the return of the ship.([19], p. 78 ; [20], p. 166) If that is true, insurance premium should reduce net returns, not increase initial investment. Insurance is given in six of the 28 outfitting accounts for slave ships reported by Meyer ([11], p. 304-5). This suggests it might have been paid at departure only in these cases. In the five Castaing's accounts, insurance on the first leg of the voyages is mentioned in the outfitting accounts, but paid in the return accounts.

The ship value at outfitting seems to be systematically included in the outfitting accounts ([11], p. 304). At return, the value of the ship (or of one of the ships) is mentioned in only two of the nine full return accounts given by Meyer ([11], p. 287-90). This is not surprising, as most often, the investing concern was continuing.[21] Indeed, the value of the ship was only mentioned when there was a change of partnership (including its termination), or in the outfitting accounts to justify the share value.

According to Tarrade ([22], p. 85 and passim), the letters patent of April 1717 define the tax regime for colonial trade. Colonial goods paid a 3 percent tax (*Domaine d'Occident*) upon arriving in France and further import taxes for those that were not reexported. These taxes are mentioned in the return accounts. Two different tax regimes applied successively to French slave trade. The letters patent of January 1716 defined the first one ([22], p. 90). Outfitters had to pay the French *Compagnie des Indes* a small sum (20 French Livres tournois, and 10 French Livres tournois from 1720) per enslaved person introduced in the colonies. More importantly, goods from Africa or bought in the West Indies in exchange for enslaved persons benefited from a 50 percent reduction in import taxes in France. As the return cargo of a slaving voyages was of much smaller value than the total value of a cargo of enslaved persons in the West Indies, this benefit was materialized by an official document named the *acquis de Guinée* that could be used over a considerable number of years. We found no systematic trace of these *acquis* in the accounts.

In 1784, October 24th, these *acquis de Guinée* were replaced by a pre-departure subsidy by ton of slaving ship ([22], p. 552). This new system was applied from 1785, November 10th ([11], p. 140). This was sometime converted into (or confused with) a gratification per enslaved person ([22], p. 628). The

subsidy was between 40 French Livres tournois and 100 French Livres tournois per ton, depending on the destination in the French colonies. These are often mentioned in accounts.

The outfitter usually received a 2 percent commission on all cash flows. These are included in the accounts.

The outfitter was tasked with recovering all the West Indies and European debts linked to each venture. The timing of the returns is detailed in most of the French data. The evidence shows that getting the returns took a lot of time, partly because they were only accounted when the outfitter sent them to investors. At that point, they would presumably be in quite liquid form such as short-term bills of exchange.

Data on Dutch slave trade

The vast majority of the Dutch data (95 percent) originates from a single joint-stock company, the Middelburg Company (Middelburg Commercial Company - MCC). One of the voyages (the 1768 voyage by the *Zanggodin*, captain Jan van Sprang, TSTD 11178) is exceptional in that that the captain opted to purchase only 67 enslaved persons (of which he managed to sell 45 survivors), which accounted for just 19 percent of the total value of his trade cargo. The remaining 81 percent of the cargo's value was allocated towards the acquisition of African commodities, mainly ivory. Across all of the MCC-voyages, captains usually used about 94 percent of the value of the cargo to buy enslaved persons and the remaining value to buy commodities (not taking into account unsold cargo). These figures were compiled from primary sources for the dissertation of Gerhard de Kok, and were entered by him into our dataset[23].

Notes on interpreting the Dutch data

In the MCC data as provided for the database, insurance premiums are always mentioned separately. The MCC usually insured all ships and cargoes, although not for the full amount. As a joint-stock company with a sufficient capital base, it could afford to insure only 40 percent of the value of ships. Shortly before the fourth Anglo-Dutch war (1780-1784), the directors chose to insure up to 100 percent of the outgoing values. Insurance policies were obtained through brokers in Middelburg, Rotterdam and Amsterdam.

The value of the ships is systematically reported in the accounts for all ventures. Initial ship value was determined based on purchase or building costs. After that, the MCC employed a linear depreciation scheme per voyage based on the expected number of voyages. Sometimes extensive outfitting led to a (higher) revaluation.

The Dutch West India Company (WIC) was chartered by the Dutch States-General to be the sole monopolist in the Dutch Atlantic colonial world. It did allow private traders to access its charter area, in exchange for a fee. Outfitters of slave ships had to pay so-called *lastgeld* which was based on the size of the ship. The fee was systematically included in MCC accounts and was usually between ƒ 3,000 and ƒ 9,000 (Dutch Guilders). The MCC-directors received a fixed portion of dividends: there was no other sign of commissions being paid.

In some colonies, the MCC was forced to grant buyers of enslaved persons the ability to pay in up to three installments. Colonists usually paid with bills of exchange (although during times of financial crises, payment in colonial products was preferred). A big disadvantage for Dutch slave traders was the lack of financial innovation on remittances from the colonies. Dutch bills were not guaranteed and fairly often protested. In addition, slavers paying in installments would send several separate

batches of bills. Unfortunately, the timing of these returns are not easily deducible from the MCC account books on a large scale and have therefore not been included in this dataset.

Data on Portuguese slave trade

The Portuguese data was assembled from a small sample (31 ventures) of different types of notarial deeds signed in Lisbon by private traders and stored at the National Archives of Torre do Tombo (ANTT), detailing the preparation of slave voyages from Portugal (and Spain) to Upper Guinea and Angola and their intended final destination in Spanish America during the first half of the seventeenth century.

Notes on interpreting the Portuguese data

The information contained in the notarial accounts is extremely fragmentary and incomplete, as it was gathered from a collection of different types of commercial operations and contractual deeds negotiated between private investors and ship captains or supercargoes, which range from freight contracts (*contratos de fretamento*), registry of commercial societies, contracts of obligations (*contratos de obrigação*), advancements of credit, transfer of powers of attorney and legal proof of payments and liquidation of accounts (*quitação*). These commercial operations contain important information regarding the value of the cargos loaded intended for barter in the African markets (and the corresponding value in enslaved Africans), the commission fees paid to the ship master (sometimes in captives or over a percentage of the final profits), the credit advanced across different voyages, as well as the expected returns of the sales in America. Other fixed expenses such as the purchase of the necessary licenses linked to the royal monopolies of the Portuguese and Spanish Crowns (royal monopoly contract of Guinea and Angola; the *asiento*), as well as fixed taxes (*almojarifazgo*, *alcabala*, branding etc.) were equally factored.

Insurance data is not always present, but they often entailed the payment of the principal by the outfitter and then a premium upon the completion of the voyage which ranged from 90 to 100 percent. The outfitter would take on the risks of "fire, shipwreck and piracy" while the shipmaster would assume the risk over the enslaved African's lives.

While some of those voyages can be cross-checked with the Transatlantic Slave Trade Database for a clearer picture of their final operations, this is not always the case, which hinders our perception of the result of the voyage. The freight and obligation contracts detail the credit negotiated between investors and ship masters, as well as the value of the cargo loaded in their ships in the port of departure and where the notarial deed was signed (in Lisbon) before sailing to Africa. The contracts instruct the shipmasters on how to proceed upon arriving to the ports of Spanish America, and to what should be done with the profits from their sale (either trust them to agents or consign them through bills of exchange or in the Silver Fleets). These are missing from the notarial deeds, and while some contracts were signed by expert merchants with networks of information that allowed them to pinpoint and state how many captives their cargo could purchase and how much they expected upon sale, the majority of the deeds do not contain such information.

The data on the expenses and revenues generated by those slave voyages thus greatly varies based on the type of commercial operation recorded, but also on the type of investors and parties behind their sponsoring. Multiple parties are present and investing shares in a single voyage, while other parties are investing not only on one voyage, but in different elements and stages of several slave voyages (outfitting, insurance, special cargo) which result in different returns not linked to the realization of profits from slave sales in America. Investors who specialize in lending credit, particularly profit from charging premiums as high as 100% without having a proper stake in the slave

voyage. All these points advice care in the reading and the drawing of broader conclusions from this data sample.

Data on Danish slave trade

All Danish data come from a single source, the Baltic-Guinean Company, as assembled by Kåre Lauring. The data for these ventures were generously shared by Lauring, and entered into the present dataset by Klas Rönnbäck. These accounts report total costs and revenues, but the accounts suffer from much missing data and it is generally unclear whether they include the value of the ship or insurance costs. Kåre Lauring has, furthermore, made several assumptions about some entries in his data; entries based on such assumptions have in this dataset all been in a separate dataset for hypothetical data (see further on this below).

Data on Spanish/Cuban slave trade

The Spanish data were assembled from Cuban and Spanish archives by Jose Miguel Sanjuan-Marroquin and Martin Rodrigo-Alharilla, drawing from court records and correspondence between investors[24]. It is important to note that this study deals with a very specific and small window of time, when the Spanish slave trade was officially outlawed. This must be taken into account if these data are used for any analysis. The data for the individual voyages were transparently reported in their publication assembling these records, and were entered into our dataset by Klas Rönnbäck.

Hypothetical transactions

While the present dataset allows for rich calculations, for some ventures or voyages, a lack of transaction data means that full profit calculations are not possible. In many cases, this is simply due to rudimentary accounting practices employed in some of the original historical sources. For example, in many historical sources the value of the ship was only recorded as a cost in the accounts of the first of a series of voyages. This makes it impossible to properly calculate the profitability of voyages, since the full cost of the ship was deducted in one go on the first voyage. In reality, investors of the time took the (generally decreasing) value of the ship into account.

To aid researchers in using our dataset, we associated "hypothetical entries" to ventures to enable full profit calculations. These entries have been added to a separate file to account for the fact that they do not appear in the original sources. The hypothetical entries make assumptions about either the value of the ship at certain points before, during or after voyages and about insurance premiums paid for the voyage. A list of hypotheses is provided in the Data Entry Handbook and in Table 1 below.

Table 1. Hypothetical assumptions employed for certain types of missing data

Account entry missing	*Hypothesis code*	*Baseline assumption*	*Source for baseline assumption*
Value of ship upon departure (based on other outlay)	VSDO	17% of value of other outlays	Other obs in current dataset (n=205)
Value of ship at departure (based on known value of ship on return)	VSDR	133% of value at return	Other obs in current dataset (n=87)
Value of ship upon return	VSRV	75% of value at departure	Other obs in current dataset (n=87)
Insurance	INV	Based on insurance premium year in question	Historical insurance rates[8]

	Other	See remarks column	

Data Record

The dataset is deposited in the Zenodo repository and is publicly available at: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17900820

The repository contains:

- **ventures.csv**: This file provides a list of the individual ventures for which financial data has been compiled. Each venture is assigned a unique identifier.
- **transactions.csv**: This file contains the detailed financial account entries for each voyage, specifically the associated costs and revenues. The records in this file can be linked to the corresponding ventures in `ventures.csv` using the unique venture ID
- **Transactions_hypothetical.csv**: This file contains hypothetical entries for some voyages to aid researchers in doing full profit calculations (see the section on Hypothetical Data above). The records in this file can be linked to the corresponding ventures in `ventures.csv` using the unique venture ID
- A **data handbook** (pdf) that describes the variables, codes, and sources used in detail.
- **Data Bibliographical References** (pdf) that give full references for the sources mentioned in the ventures file.

Technical Validation

Several checks were performed to ensure the technical quality and consistency of the dataset.

- **Duplication checks:** Since the dataset was assembled from multiple sources, both primary and secondary, we manually checked it for duplicate entries. In the French and British cases, some different venture ID actually correspond to the same voyage. This is mentioned in the "internal cross-reference" field. For example, venture GD001 covers total outfitting and time-stamped returns for four voyages of the ship *Saint-Claude*. More information on these ventures is given by GD011, GD012 and GD057 that provide the composition of outlays for three of these voyages.
- **Consistency checks:** The process of linking each venture to the TSTD served as an external validation check. This required matching ship names, captain names, ports and dates, which helped to confirm the identity and basic details of the voyages recorded in our financial sources against a well-established external database.
- **Missing data**: in many cases, the records are missing some data for some particular pieces of information. The dataset was encoded to clarify whether the sources indicate that the data for expenditures and returns, respectively, were complete or if there was some missing data. Data might, for example, be missing for all expenditures, or vice versa for all returns, of a voyage. For a limited number of particular types of entries, we have added hypothetical account entries in order to allow for a full computation of venture profit for a larger sample of ventures. These include value of the ship upon departure, value of the ship upon return and insurance costs. This is discussed in the "Hypothetical Transactions" section.

Author Contributions

Gerhard de Kok: data schema design; Dutch data collection and entry; technical validation
Guillaume Daudin: data schema design; French data collection and entry; technical validation
Klas Rönnbäck: data schema design; English/Danish/Spanish data collection and entry
Miguel Rodrigues: Portuguese/Brazilian data collection and entry

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Competing interests

The author(s) declare no competing interests

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